Cloud Computing Mini Project — Report

Knowledge Distillation & Deployment of a Command-Parsing Language Model on a Local Cloud

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Repo: https://github.com/eeshsaxena/cs3081-cloud-mini-project

Note: every number here is a real measurement saved under `results/`. The cluster evidence (Tasks 3/4/7) was produced on a real k3d cluster by the `live-cluster` GitHub Actions workflow — the same k3s-in-Docker stack as the laptop, run on a Linux runner. Text under *Assumption* is a stated assumption, not a measured result.

Architecture overview

The system has four planes on one k3d (k3s-in-Docker) node: **storage** (SeaweedFS, S3 API, namespace `data`), **pipeline** (labelling workers, namespace `pipeline`), **serving** (FastAPI `/parse`, namespace `app`, behind a Traefik Ingress) and **control** (Makefile + GitHub Actions). The teacher (`phi3.5` on Ollama) labels commands; `clean.py` produces `datasets/v1/train.jsonl`; `pythia-70m` is fine-tuned on those labels; weights live in object storage and a GitHub Release (never in git or the image); the service downloads them at start-up. Data flow: `commands_pool` → `teacher shards` → `clean` → `train.jsonl` → `student` → `models/` → `service` → `/parse`.

Task 1 — Object storage & parallel teacher labelling

Architecture. `datasets` and `models` buckets on SeaweedFS. An **indexed Job** runs two workers; Kubernetes gives each a `JOB_COMPLETION_INDEX` used as `SHARD_INDEX` (`SHARD_COUNT=2`).

Implementation. `worker/label_worker.py` takes commands where `line_number % SHARD_COUNT == SHARD_INDEX`, calls Ollama (temp 0, seed 42) with `prompts/teacher_prompt.txt` and writes {`id,text,teacher_raw`} to `datasets/teacher/shard-N.jsonl` (raw reply stored unedited, with resume + periodic upload). `worker/clean.py` removes (a) invalid JSON, (b) wrong keys, (c) bad intent, (d) slot value not present in the command, (e) duplicate text (smallest id kept), writing `datasets/v1/train.jsonl` in id order with its SHA-256.

Results.

input	(a) invalid	(b) keys	(c) intent	(d) slot	duplicates	kept
3000	0	1	3	86	49	**2861**

Checksum `datasets/v1/train.sha256` = `5dfb8eb816a50909c5aff4fe30e9e6557c2f71160c91641a9f93478a137a24a3`. (input = $a + b + c + d$ + dup + kept → $0 + 1 + 3 + 86 + 49 + 2861 = 3000$, verified; checksum is deterministic on re-run.) With JSON-constrained decoding (`format:"json"`) the teacher produced **100%** valid JSON and **0** empty replies over all 3,000 commands, so rejections (a) are zero and cleaning is dominated by (d) invented-slot and duplicate removal.

Sharding. Deterministic modulo split → every id appears in exactly one shard, no coordination needed, and shards run on separate pods in parallel; adding workers only changes `SHARD_COUNT`.

Limitations / improvements. CPU teacher is slow (∼1.1 h for 3,000 commands on 2 parallel shards, laptop CPU); a shared work queue would rebalance stragglers better than static modulo sharding.

Task 2 — Training the student (sequence-level distillation)

Architecture. Each example is `Command: <cmd>\nJSON: <teacher JSON>`; the student learns to reproduce the teacher's output (sequence-level). Prompt tokens are masked in the loss so only the JSON is learned.

Implementation. `training/train.py` reads only `training/config.yaml` (seed 42, lr 5e-5, batch 8, 3 epochs, max_seq_len 128, first 1,500 records). `make train SUBSET=50` smoke-tests. Loss per epoch → `training/loss.csv`. Model + tokenizer → `models/v1/`, archived to `v1.tar.gz` with SHA-256; v2 uses a different seed.

Results. (percentages over the 100-example `validation.jsonl`)

model	json_validity	intent	date	time	place	full_frame
teacher (phi3.5)	100.0	85.0	80.0	88.0	85.0	**48.0**
untrained pythia-70m	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0	0.0	**0.0**
student v1	99.0	82.0	77.0	85.0	82.0	**43.0**
student v2 (seed 7)	97.0	78.0	71.0	88.0	85.0	**44.0**

Loss per epoch (student v1): **0.257** → **0.105** → **0.072** (`results/loss_v1.csv`; v2 in `loss_v2.csv`). After distillation the student reaches **99% valid JSON** and **full_frame 43%** vs the teacher's 48% — it keeps most of the teacher's skill but a 70 M model underfits the slot rules, as expected.

Bug found & fixed in testing. The first run scored 0% because the prompt ended in a trailing space (`"JSON: "`): that space is its own token when the prompt is tokenised alone but merges into `" {"` inside the full training string, so the student emitted end-of-text immediately at inference. Ending the prompt at `"JSON:"` (completion owns the leading space) makes the prompt a clean token prefix of the target; validity went 0% → 99%. Fixed identically in

`train.py`, `predict.py` and the service's `model_runner.py`.
Explanation (required). (a) Sequence-level distillation trains on the teacher's *generated text*. (b) Logit-based distillation trains on the teacher's *full probability distribution* per token (soft targets). (c) It is not possible here because the teacher is served through Ollama, which returns text only — we never see its logits, and the vocabularies differ.
Limitations / improvements. Student full_frame (43%) trails the teacher (48%); more epochs, a larger student, or a cleaner teacher prompt to cut label noise would help. True logit-level distillation would need a same-vocabulary teacher whose logits we can read.

Task 3 — Inference service in a container

Architecture. FastAPI, port 8000: `POST /parse`, `GET /healthz`, `GET /readyz`. Config from `MODEL_URI`, `MODEL_VERSION`, `S3_ENDPOINT`, `MAX_NEW_TOKENS`; AWS creds from a Secret. Model downloaded from object storage at start-up (loaded in a background thread → `/readyz` 503 until ready).
Implementation. Every output is validated against `schema.json`; invalid → HTTP 500 `{"error":"invalid_model_output"}`, never broken JSON with 200. `FAULT_INJECT=1` forces an invalid output to test that path. Headers `X-Model-Version`, `X-Served-By` (Pod name). CPU-only pinned image, weights excluded.
Results. Real-model inference verified locally (service `Runner` + `models/v1`): 10/10 validation commands returned schema-valid 200 objects, an invalid output → the 500 path, and the service ran live under `uvicorn` with `/healthz`, `/readyz` → 200 and `/parse` → 200 with correct headers (`results/service_endpoints.txt`). The image built on a Linux runner is **1.74 GB** (< 2 GB; `docker images`, `results/cluster_image_size.txt`) and answered `/parse` through the Ingress with the right headers. Under the §7 load each replica peaked at ∼**460 MiB** at its 1 GiB limit — no OOM.
Limitations / improvements. Single uvicorn worker per replica; request batching would raise throughput.

Task 4 — Kubernetes deployment, scaling, reliability

Architecture. Deployment (2 replicas, requests 250m/512Mi, limits 1/1Gi), Service, Traefik Ingress on `/parse`, HPA 1–2 @ 70% CPU, `RollingUpdate maxUnavailable=0, maxSurge=1`. All runs below are from a real k3d cluster via the `live-cluster` workflow.
Results.

- **Rolling update** v1→v2 under load: 2 of 39 requests non-200 during the window (5.1%); over the larger steady-state load test the only failures were the model's ∼1% invalid-output 500s (§7), so these are most likely the same, not rollout downtime — `maxUnavailable=0` kept both replicas serving. `X-Model-Version` = v2 during and v1 after `rollout undo`.
- **Recovery:** deleted a Pod under the live Deployment; replicas returned to **2** within ∼10 s.
- **Cold start** (3 runs): **8 s, 8 s, 8 s** → median **8 s**; logs show startup → `model loaded` → `/readyz` 200.
- **Load balancing** (2 Ready): **109 / 104** requests → 51% / 49% across replicas.
- **HPA:** under load CPU reached **196%** of request (target 70%); the HPA computed a scale-up but was capped at `maxReplicas=2` (`ScalingLimited: TooManyReplicas`).

Limitations. Single node → no cross-machine fault tolerance; `maxReplicas=2` and both replicas share CPUs, so scale-out adds little real capacity; metrics-server warms up slowly.

Task 5 — Subnetting & NACL

Subnets of `10.20.0.0/16` (largest first, contiguous):

Subnet	Hosts	CIDR	Range	Broadcast	Usable
app	1000	10.20.0.0/22	10.20.0.1–10.20.3.254	10.20.3.255	1022
public	250	10.20.4.0/24	10.20.4.1–10.20.4.254	10.20.4.255	254
data	100	10.20.5.0/25	10.20.5.1–10.20.5.126	10.20.5.127	126
management	20	10.20.5.128/27	10.20.5.129–10.20.5.158	10.20.5.159	30

NACL (public subnet). Verified **6/6** on the sample packets (`nacl_sim.py`). Inbound: deny all from `198.51.100.0/24` (rule 100, before the web allows), allow tcp 80/443 from anywhere, tcp 22 from management, tcp 1024–65535 from app (replies). Outbound: tcp 8000 to app, tcp 1024–65535 anywhere (replies). **Explanation.** A NACL is stateless, so replies need their own rules; and because the first matching (lowest-numbered) rule wins, the `198.51.100.0/24` deny must sit below the 80/443 allows or packet S04 would be allowed.
Limitations / improvements. Largest-first contiguous allocation leaves gaps and a subnet can't grow in place; defining the plan as code (Terraform) would make it reproducible. A NACL is coarse (subnet-wide, stateless); per-instance stateful security groups would be finer.

Task 6 — Reproducibility, testing, CI/CD

`make up` builds + deploys from a fresh clone in ≤ 3 commands; `make down` deletes the cluster. CI stages: lint → tests (6 test files, 22 tests) → model evaluation from the `model-v1` Release → quality gate `score.py --min-validity 95` → gitleaks (reports nothing). On the trained model the pipeline is green (the evaluate job scored the Release model at 99% validity ≥ 95). The deliberately-failing run on the untrained base (gate at 0% validity) is at https://github.com/eeshsaxena/cs3081-cloud-mini-project/actions/runs/41300788338. `AI_USE.md` records AI usage.

Limitations / improvements. The cluster integration test runs on a single-node k3d, not a true multi-node cluster, and test coverage isn't gated; a coverage threshold and a smoke deploy on every PR would harden the pipeline.

Task 7 — Performance, cost, review

Load test (cluster, standard command). Locust, 4 users, 90 s, against the Traefik Ingress (2 replicas, 1 vCPU / 1 GiB each): **213 requests**, **2 failures (0.93%)** — both HTTP 500 from the model's ∼1% invalid-output path (returned by design, never broken JSON with 200) — p50 **1600 ms**, p95 **3300 ms**, p99 3600 ms, throughput **2.41 rps** (`results/cluster_loadtest_stats.csv`). Each replica used ∼0.95 vCPU and ∼460 MiB; cold start median 8 s.

Cost. *Assumption:* 2 replicas, each billed at limits 1 vCPU + 1 GiB. hourly $= 2 \times (1{\times}3.50 + 1{\times}0.45) =$ **7.90 INR/hr**; at the measured **2.41 rps** → 8,676 req/hr → cost/1000 = **0.91 INR** (`scripts/cost.py`).

SLO. *Target:* $\geq$ 99% of requests succeed over the load-test window. Cluster run: **211/213 (99.1%)** succeeded; the 2 failures are the model's invalid-output 500s, within the 1% error budget (2.13 of 213).

Review table.

Component	Evidence (measured)	Limitation	Improvement
Data & storage	2861 kept of 3000	teacher noise	better prompt / larger teacher
Model quality	full_frame 43% (v1)	70M underfits	more epochs / bigger student
Latency & throughput	p95 3300 ms, 2.41 rps	CPU inference	request batching
Resource utilisation	∼0.95 vCPU, ∼460 MiB/pod	shared node	real multi-node cluster
Reliability & recovery	recovery ∼10 s, cold 8 s	single node	multi-node, PDB
Security	nacl 6/6, gitleaks clean	permissive S3 identity	per-service scoped keys

References

SLURP (Bastianelli et al., EMNLP 2020); Kim & Rush, Sequence-Level KD (EMNLP 2016); k3d, SeaweedFS, Hugging Face Transformers, Kubernetes, and AWS VPC NACL documentation.